

23, A Renewed Critique of Byzantium

Although it undeniably carries a strong hue of my personal sentiment, I must voice a critique against the Byzantine emperors: they were fundamentally cut from the exact same cloth (一丘之貉) as the monarchs of China's **restoration-bureaucratic period**.

As a state born amidst the surging tide of **feudalization**, Byzantium did not develop a uniquely Byzantine iteration of a **feudal system** until the 11th century, during the reign of Alexios I Komnenos (阿莱克修斯科穆宁一世)—a system known in scholarship as the **Pronoia system** (普罗尼亚制). The Pronoia system emerged chronologically later than the **Iqta system**, yet the two bore striking structural similarities. Through the Pronoia system, the Byzantine emperor granted the *usufruct* (收益权 / revenue rights) of land to individuals. This right was strictly non-transferable and hereditary transmission was explicitly prohibited; simultaneously, absolute ownership of the land remained firmly vested in the emperor.

Generally, the grantee could enjoy the land's revenue rights for life, but the emperor retained the absolute despotic power to revoke the grant arbitrarily. Crucially, individuals granted a *Pronoia* did not bear specific, institutionalized military obligations. While the emperor could compel them to participate in military campaigns, this duty lacked systemic institutionalization.

This was certainly not a manifestation of the Byzantine emperors' benevolent desire to protect their ministers. The fundamental calculus of the Byzantine emperors did not differ an iota from that of Chinese monarchs: **Once the feudal landlord class was permitted to universally shoulder institutionalized military obligations, there would be absolutely nothing capable of obstructing their mutation into true feudal lords!** Furthermore, if the grantees operated as "short-term tenants" rather than "long-term operators," they were highly likely to ruthlessly exploit and strip-mine the land to extract maximum profit before its inevitable revocation, thereby aggressively accelerating the exhaustion of **social efficiency** (社会效率).

Consequently, during the precarious, tempestuous twilight of Byzantium, we observe an utterly absurd phenomenon: the Byzantine emperors overwhelmingly preferred to place their trust in pagan mercenary companies rather than take a single step further toward **feudalization** in their internal power dynamics! This is indeed a profoundly "Chinese" political ideology: **Better that everyone loses than to allow anyone to win; better to be ruled by outsiders than to allow one's own subjects to gain power** (宁可所有人都输，不能让任何人赢；宁可让外人统治，不能让自己人得势).

The limited compromises the Byzantine emperors did make were nothing more than the inevitable result of the advancing **feudalization** process, exacerbated by the compounding threats of internal aristocratic rebellions and external invaders. We have every reason to believe that if the geopolitical situation of the Byzantine Empire had genuinely stabilized during the Komnenian Dynasty, those aristocrats granted *Pronoia* would highly likely have been systematically purged!

After all, the **Theme system** (军区制), which emerged much earlier during the Heraclian Dynasty, had already exhibited glaring **feudal characteristics** and had rendered monumental contributions in resisting Islamic expansion. Yet, the moment the emperors of the Macedonian Dynasty convinced themselves that the empire had experienced a resurgence, they exhausted every conceivable method to suppress and dismantle those increasingly feudalized "provincial military governors" (藩镇武人). The empire pivoted toward deploying smaller, more flexible military units to launch

counteroffensives along the borders (*facilitated by the ongoing disintegration of the Arab Empire*), and the remuneration for military service reverted from land grants back to cash payments.

In the absence of a truly existential adversary, these policies genuinely engineered an illusion of flourishing prosperity. However, the deeply layered, defense-in-depth military structure originally forged by the Theme system was irreparably dismantled (*ironically, constructing such defense-in-depth was exactly what numerous Southern Song officials advocated for in the early years of that dynasty*).

Byzantium obstinately delayed adopting a **quasi-feudal system** like *Pronoia* until even later than the Muslims. Moreover, concerning the integration of military power and obligations, the *Pronoia* was even further removed from a genuine **feudal system** than the *Iqta* system was. Consequently, the empire's ultimate failure was utterly irreversible.

By the time Michael VIII Palaiologos (米海尔八世) recaptured Constantinople in 1261, he was forced to capitulate and permit *Pronoia* to become inheritable; subsequently, holders of *Pronoia* could even sub-grant their rights to others. Following the "baptism" by fire of the Latin Crusaders, Byzantium finally projected the image of a Western European feudal state in its absolute terminal phase.

Yet, even having reached this desperate, apocalyptic precipice, the Byzantine emperors still frantically clung to the final shreds of despotic power within an empire that practically retained nothing else! They stubbornly refused to grant *de facto* land ownership; they retained the despotic prerogative to confiscate *Pronoia*; and they refused to formally acknowledge the inherent legitimacy of hereditary succession—the inheritance of a *Pronoia* still required imperial approval, even if such approval was routinely granted. Even as the state plunged into this abyssal condition, royal relatives still furiously cannibalized each other in pursuit of a crown and throne propped up by a bureaucratic apparatus that was "dead but still twitching" (死而不僵). In reality, apart from the sheer psychological intoxication of power itself, there were absolutely no tangible benefits left to be reaped.

Such conduct—virtually indistinguishable from that of Chinese autocratic monarchs—is entirely sufficient to cement the image of numerous Byzantine emperors as political clowns engraved in human history. **Whoever obstinately refuses feudalization will inevitably be utterly annihilated by those barbarians who embrace feudalization; it is merely a question of sooner or later.**

Ironically, the demise of Byzantium perhaps holds greater historical value than the ten centuries of the empire's existence. This is because Byzantium's failure irrefutably proves a monumental thesis: **The success of Western Europe was fundamentally NOT due to the Christian faith, the cultural heritage of Greco-Roman antiquity, or any other universally acknowledged characteristics of Western civilization generated prior to the High Middle Ages!**

Byzantium possessed those exact same characteristics in abundance!

The sole and exclusive reason modern Europe could emerge was that it embarked upon the correct historical trajectory (i.e., feudalization). This specific process enabled the classical heritage to modernize in tandem with societal development, thereby incubating and generating novel early modern factors. All ideologies, cultures, and social concepts—elements that Karl Marx classified as the **superstructure** (上层建筑)—are, without exception, definitively molded and determined by the morphological realities of **social existence** (社会存在形态).

23, 对于拜占庭的再次批评

虽然显然带有我强烈的个人感情色彩，但是对于拜占庭皇帝我必须吐槽，他们与中国复辟官僚时期的君主完全是一丘之貉。拜占庭作为在封建化浪潮中诞生的国家，直到 11 世纪，阿莱克修斯科穆宁一世统治时期才发展出了一种拜占庭式的封建制度，汉语翻译为普罗尼亚制（Pronoia）。普罗尼亚制度晚于伊克塔制度出现，但是两者却十分相似。拜占庭皇帝通过普罗尼亚制度将土地的收益权授予个人，这种权益不可转让也不允许世袭，同时土地的所有权仍然归于皇帝。一般来说受赐者可以终身享有土地的收益权，但是皇帝仍然可以使用专制权力撤回赏赐。被授予普罗尼亚的人并非承担特定的军事义务，皇帝可以要求他们参加军事行动，但是却不具备制度性。这当然不是拜占庭皇帝心善保护自己的大臣，拜占庭皇帝的考虑从根本上与中国君主没有区别：一旦让封建地主阶级广泛地肩负起军事义务，那么就没有什么能阻止它们向封建领主转化了。而受封者若是“短期租客”而非“长期经营者”，他们很可能会疯狂压榨土地以在被收回前获利，从而加速了社会效率的枯竭。于是在拜占庭晚期风雨飘摇的时代，我们看到了一种十分可笑的情况，拜占庭皇帝们宁可相信异教的雇佣兵，也不愿意在权力关系中再向着封建化进一步。这的确是一种非常中国式的思想：宁可所有人都输，不能让任何人赢；宁可让外人统治，不能让自己人得势。

拜占庭的皇帝做出一定的妥协，无非是受到封建化进程的发展，内部贵族叛乱和外部侵略者内外威胁加剧的结果。我们完全有理由相信，如果拜占庭帝国的局势在科穆宁王朝时期真的能够好转，那些被赐予普罗尼亚的贵族恐怕会被清算。毕竟早在希拉克略王朝统治时期所出现的军区制（Theme）就已经表现出了明显的封建特征并且在抵抗伊斯兰扩张中立下了汗马功劳。等到马其顿王朝的皇帝自以为帝国已经复兴时，就想尽办法打压那些日益封建化的“藩镇武人”。帝国采取了更小也更灵活的军事单位在边境发起反击（因为阿拉伯帝国正在解体），兵役的酬劳重新转化为用现金支付而不是给予土地。在具有威胁性的敌人出现之前这样做确实营造了一片欣欣向荣的景象，但是原本军区制度塑造的具有纵深的军事防御体系被破坏了（这恰恰是南宋初年许多南宋官员呼吁建设的）。拜占庭硬是拖到比穆斯林还晚才采取了普罗尼亚这样的准封建制度，就军事权力和义务这一点上还不如伊克塔制更接近真正的封建体制，那么失败是无法挽回的。

等到巴列奥略王朝的米海尔八世在 1261 年收复君士坦丁堡之后，他不得不允许普罗尼亚变成可继承的，随后普罗尼亚的拥有者甚至还可以再向其他人转赠普罗尼亚。经过拉丁十字军的“洗礼”，拜占庭终于在临死前的最后一个阶段呈现出一种西欧封建国家的形象。但是即使到了这种山穷水尽的地步，拜占庭皇帝还妄图捏着这个几乎什么也不剩的帝国的最后一点权力，依然不给予事实的土地所有权，可以利用专制权力没收普罗尼亚，并且不承认世袭继承的合理性，普罗尼亚的世袭必须得到批准，哪怕一般都会批准。国家到了这般田地，皇亲国戚仍然在追逐由死而不僵的官僚体制所托举的皇冠和宝座，其实那里除了权力本身以外已经没有任何其他的收益了。像这样与中国专制君主别无二致的作为，足以让拜占庭许多皇帝以小丑的形象被镌刻在人类的历史中。谁要是拒绝封建化，谁就会被那些封建化的蛮族彻底击败，无非是早一点或者晚一点的问题。

说起来可笑的是，拜占庭的灭亡或许比这个帝国十个世纪的存在更有价值。因为拜占庭的失败无可辩驳地证明了一点，即西欧的成功不是因为什么基督教信仰，古希腊罗马文化遗产等等公认的在封建盛期之前产生的西方文明的特征，拜占庭同样存在这些特征。现代欧洲之所以能产生，唯一的原因就是它走上了正确的历史进程，使得古典遗产能够随着社会发展现代化，并且创造出新的近现代因素。所有的思想，文化，社会观念这样在马克思看来属于上层建筑的成分，的确就是由社会存在形态所塑造的。